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In the evolutionary history of life-forms, there has always been a curious phenomenon: species that dominate the ecology. Numerically, and in their capacity to impart changes on the ecosystem itself. Ideology may seem a vastly different field from biology—and it is indeed reductionist to draw a line from one to the other—but something unfolding on the Indian landscape over the last decade begs the comparison. If ideas exist in a space of contestation, locked in mutual combat, the spectacular growth of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) during the reign of Prime Minister Narendra Modi shows us a clear winner in that crowded arena. If seen as a singular organism—a metaphor that the party's tightly-knit structure invites—it looms over all other political life-forms. But that misses a key nuance. The jaw-dropping growth of the BJP has a critical feature built into it: the inclusion of others into The Singularity. Whether by conversion, cooption, appropriation or predation, citadels have been breached, self-contained political zones cracked open, and a whole roster-call of political figures from diverse backgrounds initiated into the fold. These political migrants seemingly exercised the sole option open to them if they wished to survive and thrive: join the congregation. You could call it Rex Lex—might is right—or political Darwinism. But its effect is that Saffron is now internally a Rainbow. This phase—the United Colours of the BJP, so to speak—provides a window to look at the fascinating evolution of the world's biggest political party.

The other day, it was Rahul Narwekar in focus. As the BJP sought to tighten the nuts and bolts on a frame it had hammered into shape just last week, it installed the young legislator from Colaba as speaker of the Maharashtra assembly. It's an especially crucial post at this juncture because of the upcoming battle over the ownership of the Shiv Sena, including in the assembly, where 16 rebel MLAs, now on the ruling side, face a contentious disqualification move. But the man entrusted with this onus used to be a firebrand spokesperson of Sharad Pawar's Nationalist Congress Party (NCP)—and in that capacity, a bitter critic of the BJP—till he switched camps in October 2019, just before the assembly election. Of course, like many other political migrants, he has sipped water from many ghats, having been a Shiv Sainik before 2014. Born in February 1977, just as the curtains were coming down on Indira Gandhi's Emergency, Narwekar becomes the youngest speaker in the country.

A RECENT STUDY SHOWED THAT THE BJP GAVE ASSEMBLY POLL TICKETS TO 833 TURNCOATS IN THE LAST DECADE, AND 44 PER CENT OF THEM GOT ELECTED

He's of course among the latest to step off the caravan trails winding into the BJP's massive tent city—and be rewarded for it. As many as 16 members of Modi's council of ministers have come from other parties. Of them, only tribal affairs minister Arjun Munda came on board long before Modi became a national figure—from the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha, in 1998. Kiren

Facing page: (top row L-R) R.P.N. Singh, Jyotiraditya Scindia, Jay Panda, N. Biren Singh; (middle row) Sunil Jakhar, Narayan Rane, Himanta Biswa Sarma, Hardik Patel (bottom row) Jitin Prasada, Pema Khandu, Manik Saha, Rahul Narwekar

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